

More Lumia

Nokia Lumia 900 may be unveiled at CES 2012

Canon joins the race

Canon will launch its mirrorless compact system cameras in 2012

Tablet test

THE RISE OF THE HYBRIDS



Late last year, the Dell Streak 5 was laughed off for multiple reasons, the primary being the neither this nor that display size. It was considered too uncomfortable to be a smartphone, and too small to be a tablet. Fast forward another year, and we have these mid-way devices rising up again. Aptly name genre this time, the likes of the Samsung Galaxy Note, the new Motorola Razr and the Acer Iconia Smart offer something slightly bigger than the smartphones, but smaller and easier to pocket than the 7-inch tablet. While the demographic these devices will appeal to be limited, the usefulness is unmistakable. Expect more devices in this category in 2012. And just maybe, either the definition of a big smartphone will change, or the tablets will get a smaller display size than 7-inches at the moment.

BBM client. At the moment though, you need two devices to complete the purpose of one. Not something many people find acceptable.

The Acer Iconia A500 is the first of the three Wi-Fi only tablets we're about to talk about. Tipping the scales at 730 grams, it is by far the heaviest of the lot, despite being just 13.3mm thick. The build quality is appreciative, even though we must criticise the fact that you can't really hold the A500 in one hand for more than five minutes at a stretch. Its 10.1-inch display is impressive though. It handles colours well and displays considerably crisp text. Brightness levels are quite good too, and at full brightness, you can comfortably read text in bright sunlight. Battery life is standard fare – six hours if you're watching a movie. Speaking of which, the HD video playback was smooth, and the display's crispness was more than welcome here as well. This is a huge improvement with the Android 3.2 update, considering that Android 3.0 couldn't even play most codecs natively.

Onto iPads now. The Wi-Fi only version of the Apple iPad 2 is miles ahead of the competition when it comes to sheer performance stakes. Our benchmark scores prove that to a certain extent. At 8.8mm thickness, this one is the second slimmest beauty walking the tablet ramp, with the



BlackBerry PlayBook

Galaxy Tab 750 being the slimmest. More on that later! Back to the iPad 2, and we're essentially talking about a tablet that rules the entire market single-handedly. And there's a good reason for that. The aforementioned performance figures, solid aluminum unibody build, slim and light form factor, best in the class display and the best in the class (yet again!) battery life. The 9.7-inch display means that in most

cases, the iPad 2 will be more comfortable to hold than the slightly bigger 10.1-inch IPS LED display ones. Brightness levels are by far the highest on this tablet, which it manages while retaining the individual punch of each colour – the whites remain crisp white and the blacks remain dark. Unlike most AMOLED displays (yes, we're looking at you Galaxy Tab 750), the red and orange colours don't become overbearing. It has excellent battery life, about 8-9 hours of video viewing, with Wi-Fi/3G connected in the background. For most medium load usage scenarios, this one will last about a week on a single charge!

However, the mighty iPad 2 does have some drawbacks. First, it's highly dependent on iTunes to transfer music and movies to it. For most other files, you can use services like Dropbox to get around this limitation.

Secondly, iTunes supports very limited video codecs. You can download any third-party media player to play back formats like MKV on the tablet. But even if you use a third-party media player, you still need to transfer the files to that app via the iTunes interface. This can be cumbersome.

The Sony Tablet S may be the newest arrival on the scene, but it comes with some style. Straightaway, its unique design will get your attention. Sony designers say a folded open magazine inspired the design.

The Tablet S is quite thick (at its thickest point) at 20.6 mm, but comes down 10.1 mm at the slimmest point. The wedge design does flatter to deceive to a certain extent – it's not as heavy as it looks. At 598 grams, it's slightly lighter than the iPad 2, and that says a lot. Admittedly, the Tablet S is made completely of plastic, while the iPad 2 has aluminum. Having said that, the plastic used in this case seems



Acer Iconia A500

to be very high quality, coupled with excellent build quality. We didn't feel any flex on any part of the panel. The 9.4-inch LED display does very well in terms of brightness levels, text crispness and keeping all colours on an equal tone. However, the reflective nature of the display reduces viewing angles considerably. We liked the minimalist tweaks to the Android UI – it added a dollop of functionality without really affecting performance. The standard Android keypad has been done away with, and replaced with one that offers the alphabets and number pad on the same display (reduces steps needed to access numbers and to go back). This is the first tablet to receive the PlayStation certification (no real surprises there!), and carries it on by offering the *Crash Bandicoot* and *Pinball* game on



Apple iPad 2 (Wi-Fi)